

UPSTRIDE RESOURCES

FREE PRACTICAL DIGITAL GROWTH SERIES

Business Automation Playbook

Turn repetitive work into reliable, connected workflows.

A practical guide for mapping, prioritizing, and automating operations without losing human judgment.

STRATEGY > SYSTEM > SCALE

YOUR NEXT STEP FORWARD

How to use this playbook

A practical guide for mapping, prioritizing, and automating operations without losing human judgment.

**READ**

Understand the operating model.

**ASSESS**

Score your current state honestly.

**BUILD**

Complete one focused pilot.

**REVIEW**

Use evidence to improve the system.

A note on responsible use

This free publication is for educational and planning purposes. Adapt every recommendation to your business, customers, contracts, privacy obligations, security requirements, and local laws. It is not legal, financial, accounting, cybersecurity, or regulatory advice. Product and platform capabilities change; verify current requirements before implementation.



BASELINE

Where are you now?

Rate each statement from 1 (not true yet) to 5 (consistently true). Use the lowest scores to choose your first improvement.

01 We have a shared definition of success for map.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

02 The current workflow and ownership are documented and understood.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

03 Our tools and data have clear sources of truth.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

04 Important exceptions are identified and assigned to a person.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

05 We measure outcomes, quality, and adoption - not only activity.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

06 The team reviews and improves the system on a regular cadence.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

YOUR BASELINE SCORE

6-14 START | 15-23 STABILIZE | 24-30 SCALE



THE UPSTRIDE FRAMEWORK

Five moves that build momentum

Use this sequence to move from a scattered effort to a visible, repeatable system.

01**MAP**

Set the direction and desired outcome.

02**SIMPLIFY**

Remove ambiguity and unnecessary friction.

03**CONNECT**

Create the core workflow and supporting assets.

04**CONTROL**

Launch with ownership, controls, and visibility.

05**IMPROVE**

Learn from evidence and strengthen the system.

MAP IN PRACTICE

Find the right work to automate

Start with volume, friction, delay, and error risk - not with a favorite tool.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

List recurring tasks by team and frequency

List recurring tasks by team and frequency.

2

Estimate minutes, handoffs, and failure points

Estimate minutes, handoffs, and failure points.

3

Prioritize stable processes with clear rules

Prioritize stable processes with clear rules.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

SIMPLIFY IN PRACTICE

Map the current workflow

Make every trigger, decision, owner, system, and exception visible before redesigning.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Define the start and finish conditions

Define the start and finish conditions.

2

Mark manual data entry and duplicate approvals

Mark manual data entry and duplicate approvals.

3

Separate the normal path from exceptions

Separate the normal path from exceptions.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

CONNECT IN PRACTICE

Design the future workflow

Remove unnecessary steps first; automate only the leaner version of the process.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Use one source of truth for core records

Use one source of truth for core records.

2

Assign a human owner for every exception

Assign a human owner for every exception.

3

Add alerts where silence would create risk

Add alerts where silence would create risk.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

CONTROL IN PRACTICE

Build with guardrails

Reliable automation needs permissions, validation, retries, logs, and a safe fallback.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Test with realistic sample records

Test with realistic sample records.

2

Limit access to the minimum required

Limit access to the minimum required.

3

Document how to pause and recover the flow

Document how to pause and recover the flow.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

IMPROVE IN PRACTICE

Measure and improve

Track whether the workflow saves time and improves service - not just whether it runs.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Compare cycle time before and after

Compare cycle time before and after.

2

Review exceptions every week at launch

Review exceptions every week at launch.

3

Retire steps that no longer add value

Retire steps that no longer add value.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?



MOVE FROM IDEA TO PILOT

A focused implementation sprint

Keep the first implementation narrow enough to learn quickly and important enough to matter.

1

Inventory 10 recurring workflows

DAYS 1-3

2

Score the top five opportunities

DAYS 4-7

3

Map one pilot end to end

DAYS 8-11

4

Build and test with sample data

DAYS 12-16

5

Launch to a small user group

DAYS 17-21

6

Review logs and exceptions

DAYS 22-26

7

Document and scale

DAYS 27-30



MAKE IT CONCRETE

One-page system brief

Complete this before selecting tools or building assets. Short, specific answers are more useful than broad ambition.

01 WORKFLOW NAME AND OWNER

02 TRIGGER AND DESIRED OUTCOME

03 CURRENT SYSTEMS AND DATA

04 RULES AND DECISIONS

05 EXCEPTIONS REQUIRING JUDGMENT

06 SUCCESS MEASURE AND REVIEW DATE



EVIDENCE OVER ACTIVITY

A practical scorecard

Choose a small set of measures that show customer value, operational quality, and sustainable adoption.

MEASURE	BASELINE	TARGET	CADENCE
Cycle time			
Manual touches			
Error rate			
Exception rate			
Hours returned			

REVIEW QUESTION

What changed, why did it change, and what will we do next?



READY TO MOVE FORWARD?

Final readiness check

A healthy launch has clarity, ownership, safeguards, measurement, and a defined next review.

- ☐ The desired business and customer outcome is specific.
- ☐ A named owner is accountable for the system.
- ☐ The normal workflow and important exceptions are documented.
- ☐ Data access, privacy, and security requirements are reviewed.
- ☐ Users have been trained in the real workflow.
- ☐ Success measures have baselines, targets, and owners.
- ☐ A rollback or recovery path exists where needed.
- ☐ The first improvement review is scheduled.

YOUR NEXT STEP FORWARD

Continue with Business Automation Specialist.

See the guided learning path: upstride-three.vercel.app/academy/business-automation



FREE GUIDE TO GUIDED PRACTICE

Ready to build the skill?

This playbook gives you the framework. The matching Upstride Academy program helps you apply it through structured lessons, practical projects, downloadable tools, and a capstone.

RECOMMENDED PROGRAM

Business Automation Specialist

UPSTRIDE ACADEMY | PRACTICAL, PROJECT-BASED LEARNING

What the program helps you do

1

Map and redesign real business workflows

Map and redesign real business workflows through guided exercises and feedback-ready project work.

2

Build reliable no-code automation systems

Build reliable no-code automation systems through guided exercises and feedback-ready project work.

3

Deliver a documented automation capstone

Deliver a documented automation capstone through guided exercises and feedback-ready project work.

CHOOSE YOUR SUPPORT LEVEL

Basic | Pro | Mentored

Review current package details and availability on the course page before enrolling.

View the program and enroll

upstride-three.vercel.app/academy/business-automation